



The Game Model

*How Menlo Men's Soccer builds, invades, finishes, and hunts —
codified for the staff and the players who will live it.*

THE IDENTITY STATEMENT

Territory over possession.

Chances over patterns.

Pressure over patience.

Goals over aesthetics.



EVERYTHING IN THIS DOCUMENT IS DESIGNED TO WIN GAMES

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A LIVING DOCUMENT

Content evolves; vocabulary holds. New moments are named only after they are confirmed in games.



PART ONE

Who We Are

Mission, vision, values — the foundation everything else stands on.

THE WORK

Mission

To work with student-athletes and develop their life skills in all areas so they may reach their full potential and improve the world around them.

THE FRAME

Everything in this document is designed to win games. The principles, the structures, the rituals, the training — all of it is in service of the only outcome that matters on Saturday.

THE AMBITION

Vision

Lifting trophies with future leaders of industry.

THE WHY

We compete at the highest of levels in order to bring joy to Menlo College and our collective communities — including those who have come before you in this program, and yourself. Great regular seasons and deep playoff runs ensure us of this.

THE IDENTITY STATEMENT

We value territory over possession, chances over patterns, pressure over patience, and goals over aesthetics.

The Eight Values

VALUE	WHAT IT MEANS
Selflessness	No person is bigger than the team; all actions should be for the team.
Positivity	We are constantly on the cusp of greatness in all aspects of life.
Relentless	The outcome does not determine our effort. Our effort is focused on the process.
Self-Discipline	You are responsible for you; your teammates will help.
Gratitude	Recognize the many things you can be grateful for.
Joy	We should find happiness in the process and the people around us.
Humility	Proud but not arrogant. There is still much to accomplish.
Respect	Respect self and others at all times. We respect others with our language and actions.

NOT A POSTER ON THE WALL

The values are the teaching lens. Every tactical or technical instruction is filtered through one of the eight. When we coach defending, we coach Relentless. When we coach attacking, we coach Relentless, Positivity, Selflessness.

THE MAP

Values → Game Mapping

Different moments of the game activate different values. This is the map.

MOMENT	VALUES ACTIVE
Defending	Relentless — pressure on the ball, refusal to settle; the single non-negotiable Menlo defensive identity. Self-Discipline — when it comes to 1v1 defending, tucking in on the weak side.
Attacking	Relentless + Positivity + Selflessness + Self-Discipline. Refuse to settle; every action can change the game; run for the team. High-agency, high-energy, collective. Do my actions fall in line with the overall Game Model? This keeps the game predictable for my teammates.
Transition Moments	Self-Discipline + Relentless + Selflessness. Running for the team, being pragmatic that this action could be the moment that changes the game. Suffocating the game so opponents do not have a moment to breathe.
Set Pieces	Self-Discipline — not losing your man, responsible for knowing your assignment. Selflessness — sacrifice your body at times, committing to actions, blocking shots.

THE LENS

Our values lead the way. Everything we do is taught through that lens.

SIX ELEMENTS

What Makes Us Hard to Play Against

Six elements define us across both sides of the ball — what makes us hard to play against on any field.

ELEMENT	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Compact	Few gaps between players. No joy for attackers.
Press as a Unit	Not just running. Coordinated, collective pressure that traps opponents.
Defensive Transition	The first three seconds are critical. Get behind the ball or stop the counter; keep pressure on the ball whenever possible.
Secure on the Ball	Keep it under pressure. Kill counterattacks. We attack to defend.
50/50 & Second Balls	React first. Turn loose balls into an advantage.
Attacking Transition	Relentless in attack. The opponent always feels under pressure.
Set Pieces	Organized, well rehearsed, collective, clear ideas. Attack: vertical play, numerical advantages, disciplined runs in the box, ending each sequence over the end line, territorial advantage.

THE LANGUAGE OF THE PROGRAM

The Glossary

One place, every term. Locked vocabulary that all players are taught and held to.

DEFENDING

Casting shadow

Body positioning that takes away passing options. The closer you are to the ball, the larger your shadow.

2-for-1 defending

Taking a position that allows you to defend two players at once.

Neutral position

When the ball is central with the opponent in their defensive half and we are preparing to win it back.

Pressure pocket

A location where we are trying to force the ball, depending on the defensive scheme.

Snapping

Going to win the ball when the opponent reaches a pressure pocket. A quick, explosive movement.

Sealing to one side

Keeping the ball to one side — making the field narrow and not allowing the opponent to go sideways.

Backfill

The interchange of positioning with teammates when defending.

Tucking in

Weak-side players coming closer to the rest of the team.

Stepping

Moving higher up the field.

Close lines

Stepping our lines to make sure we are compact vertically.

Closing

Applying pressure to the opposition.

Dropping

Coming closer to our own goal collectively.

Squeeze

Coming closer together to deny central penetration.

Pressing

The team concept where we defend all the way to the opponent's end line.

Tackling

Winning the ball.

1v1 defending technique

Arm across, attach at the hip, and step across or into the opponent.

TRANSITION

Proactive defending

Anticipating defensive transition while still in the attack.

Rest defense

The off-ball structure we hold while attacking, so we can defend the moment we lose the ball. Proactive defending is the mindset; rest defense is the shape. The system of runners is always bounded by it.

Repress

Immediate pressure on the ball after losing it, taken when numbers around the ball favor us. When they don't, we Sink and Squeeze.

Stretch

Player(s) who look to immediately run forward during an attacking transition.

Ending

Tactical foul to kill play in a defensive transition moment.

Sink and Squeeze

The team-wide locked response when the press is broken — the back line sinks for depth and the team squeezes toward center.

IN POSSESSION

Invalidate

The conversion of territory into chances / high xG.

Running through

Running through opposition lines of defense.

Back shoulder

Off-the-ball positioning on the back shoulder of a defender so they cannot track you and the ball at the same time.

Getting deep

Working the ball to the end line to pin the opponent back.

Set-up shape

In the final third, getting into a good shape to attack — and also to repress. 3-2-5 formation.

Pin

Positional idea that keeps the opponent locked into their defensive third.

Drop in

The #6 drops between the CBs to form a back three, pushing both outside backs higher.

Drop out

The #6 drops alongside one CB to form an asymmetric three, freeing that outside back higher.

Zone 19

The central square around the center circle, on the tactics board grid. The most dangerous place on the field to lose the ball — a turnover here becomes a counter against a shape that hasn't set.

Stay and Play

When we have a numerical advantage in wide areas, can we solve the overload locally.

In pockets

Off-the-ball positioning between the opponent's lines.

Counter switch

Playing back into the same space — initiating a switch, then coming back to the side it started from, catching defenders over-rotating.

Interchange

Changing positions with a teammate.

Playing the channel

Playing the ball into the space between the touchline and the 18-yard box, over the opponent's back line.

Half-space

The space between the vertical lines of the defensive organization. Spaces between OB and CB in a back 4.

Interior passes

A pass played inside.

Filling the box

Near-post flashing run, center of the goal mouth, framing it. The layered, codified version of this instinct is the Arrival.

Hook it

A ball into space that players are running onto.

THE ATTACKING WAVE

FOUR BEATS, AND A BREATH THAT RETURNS

Seek

Orientation before anything happens — eyes up the field before the ball arrives. Vision is high; tools may be local.

Spring

The run that unlocks a shape. Rarely solo — a system of runners, bounded by the rest defense.

The Number

Five go, five hold. The ball, three runners on time, one late — against two pivots at the top of the box and three cover. It flexes with game state on the coach's call.

The Ninja (open play)

The late strategic run in the Number, owned by the far #8 by default and transferable by call. The call is a swap, not an addition. Same instinct as the Ninja on attacking corners.

Release

Moving the ball intentionally to serve our identity: the pass, the carry, the dribble. No flicks, no low-percentage tricks.

Finish

The fourth beat. Two ways in: the Knife and the Arrival.

The Knife

The thrust. Can we cut through them clean and score right now? Half-space and wide dominant. Lives in transition too.

The Arrival

The wave — the hunting party arriving in layers: on time, blind side, double movements; near post, frame, from deep, the ninja. Arrival over brilliance.

Hunting Party

Deliberate dual use: we hunt the ball out of possession and we hunt goals in the box. Same appetite, both sides of the ball.

Reload

The return arc, in possession only. The breath before the next attack and our lever on tempo. Not fifth in a line — available from any beat.

SYSTEM VOCABULARY

The Cycle: Build · Invade · Hunt (Section II). Pressing Structures: Solo · Hex · Hex+ · Horns · Lock — triggers Step · Seal · Snap (Section III). Attacking Moments: ½ Space · Up-Back-Through · Diagonal Ball · Cutback (Section III). Set Piece Roles: Decision Maker · Cover · Ninja · Screener · Target (Section V).



PART TWO

How We Play

The Cycle, the Attacking Wave that runs inside it, and the bridge principles that connect everything.

THREE PHASES, THREE VERBS

The Cycle

The game has four phases. Menlo names them with verbs because verbs imply action and intent.

PHASE	WHAT WE ARE DOING
Build	Build to advance and win territory.
Invade	Possession deployed to create chances. Once we have territory, we use it.
Finish	The conversion of chances into goals. The culmination — everything the Build and the Invade earned, cashed in.
Hunt	Deny the opponent and win the ball back. When we don't have it, we go get it.

The Invade–Finish seam: Invade turns territory into chances; Finish turns chances into goals. Entry versus conversion. Finish is the phase that owns everything in and around the opponent’s box.

NAMING NOTE

Finish names both the fourth phase of the Cycle and the fourth beat of the Wave — and it means the same thing in both: converting into goals. The phase is where we are; the beat is what we do. They rhyme on purpose.

Build

Building the ball forward, not keeping it. Earning the right to advance through good shape and good decisions.

THE PRINCIPLE

Build is not possession for its own sake. It is the deliberate act of building forward — earning territory by working the ball through, over, or around the lines and into a position where we can invade. A long ball is an outlet, not a default.

PROTECT ZONE 19

The central square that engulfs the center circle is the most dangerous zone for us to lose the ball — turnovers here become counterattacks against our shape before we can recover. Build through it, around it, over it, but do not lose it there. The zone grid lives on the tactics board.

THE STANDARD

We build forward. We do not keep the ball for its own sake.

Invade

Once we have territory, we use it. Penetrate, pin, set the shape — but always with the moment dictating which one.

THE PRINCIPLE

Invade is the conversion of territory into chances. Possession is the input; the output is shots, set pieces, or the opponent forced to defend deep with a broken shape. Football itself is invasive, and the first and primary objective is always to get to the final third quickly and create.

FIRST LOOK FORWARD

Every regain triggers a vertical scan first. Can we go forward immediately? If yes, we go. If no — and only if no — we Reload to set up a better attack.

PENETRATES OR PINS

A vertical ball into a high target either penetrates (the receiver turns and attacks) or pins (the receiver holds, the opponent collapses backward, we secure and progress). Both outcomes win.

THE READ

The vertical option is the default. The safe pass is the alternative.

FOUR BEATS FORWARD, AND A BREATH THAT RETURNS

The Attacking Spine

THE ONE IDEA

**Attack is movement-led, not ball-led. The runner leads.
The ball follows the picture.**

BEAT ONE

Seek

The disposition

Orientation before anything happens. Before the ball arrives, the seeker has already looked: the far side, the space behind, the picture two passes ahead. Seek is not an action; it is a disposition that never turns off. First Look Forward is Seek at its most urgent.

Spring

The run

Movement that unlocks a shape. This is the engine of the whole model. Two things are non-negotiable: it is rarely solo — the protagonist is a system of runners, not one man — and it is bounded by the rest defense.

THE CENTERPIECE OF THE ATTACKING INSTALL

The Number — Five Go, Five Hold

FIVE GO

The ball, three runners on time, one late. The carrier, three runners arriving on time (near post, center, frame), and one late strategic run — the Ninja.

FIVE HOLD

Two pivots at the top of the box — the #6 and the ball-side #8 — plus three cover. They are the repress line and the Reload outlet at once.

THE NINJA SWAP

The late run is the Ninja. The far #8 owns it by default. It can be transferred by call — the natural pair is weak-side outside back and far #8 — but the call is a swap, not an addition: whoever takes the Ninja, someone fills the slot he left. We never end up with six.

FLEXES WITH GAME STATE

Five and five is the default. Chasing, we expand it. Protecting a lead, we reduce it. The coach calls the change; players do not decide it individually.

BEAT THREE

Release

Move the ball intentionally to serve our identity. Three tools, one job: the pass, the carry, the dribble. No flicks, no low-percentage tricks — protect the ball. Release carries the vertical rule with it.

BEAT FOUR

Finish

The Knife. Can we cut through them clean and score right now? Half-space and wide dominant. Lives in transition as much as in possession.

The Arrival. The wave arrives: on time (near post, center, frame) and the Ninja from deep. The same four runs counted in Spring — the Number is the picture; the Arrival is the picture arriving.

RETURN ARC

Reload

Not the fifth box in a row. Available from any beat, in possession only. The breath before the next attack, and our lever on tempo. The negative ball is a summons, not a retreat.

THE BEAT ORDER

Seek · Spring · Release · Finish — and Reload from any beat.

The Eight Attacking Principles

- 0 **A run is never wasted, only converted.**
- 1 **Cut, don't trace. Diagonal to how they face.**
- 2 **The negative ball is a summons, not a retreat.**
- 3 **The runner carries the risk. The passer carries the ball.**
- 4 **The protagonist is never solo — a system of runners.**
- 5 **The system of runners is bounded by the rest defense.**
- 6 **Deception before arrival.**
- 7 **No flicks, no low-percentage tricks. Protect the ball.**

Score Two

9–0–0 WHEN WE SCORED TWO OR MORE	2–4–2 WHEN WE SCORED ONE OR NONE	53% NINE OF SEVENTEEN MATCHES REACHED TWO
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The 2025 season told us exactly what the job is. Score two and we do not lose. The standard going forward: two or more goals in 75% of matches — roughly thirteen of seventeen, four more matches a season.

THE SCORE TWO STANDARD

Two or more goals, three matches in four.

Hunt

Out of possession. Pressure on the ball, compactness, counterpressing. Three defending principles, expressed through five named structures.

THE PRINCIPLE

Hunt is what we do when the opponent has the ball. Three sub-principles: pressure on the ball, compactness between lines, counterpressing on every loss. With two strikers and an aggressive midfield, the preference is to be the aggressor.

THE CORE READ

Hunt when we have numbers. Deny central penetration when we don't. If we have a numerical advantage around the ball, we press. If we don't, we find our shape, deny the central pass, and force the opponent long or into a bad decision.

ON LOSS

Hyper-mobile, aware, communicative. The first three seconds after losing the ball define the next thirty. Players repress immediately when numbers favor, and Sink and Squeeze when they don't.

THE STANDARD

Team defending is not reckless. It is Relentless.

The Bridge Principles

Three meta-principles that operate across all phases — the read-based rules that tell a player what to do in any moment.

1. Numbers Around the Ball Decide the Action

Not “what zone am I in” or “what is my role” — but do we have the numbers right here, right now? Hunt: press when numbers favor. Invade transition: cluster relationally when numbers favor on regain. CB offensive transition: step when we have numbers, hold when we don't. Defensive transition: repress when we have numbers, reset when we don't. Set piece second balls: numbers decide who wins it.

2. In Possession Is Read-Based. Out of Possession Is Locked.

In possession, our shape adapts to opponent press, game state, and personnel. Out of possession, our shape is locked to the named press structure called by the coach. This is why so much of the role documentation is deliberately “dependent” — we don't over-specify what is genuinely read-based.

3. Zones of Permission

Positional in the build, hybrid in the middle, relational around the box. The full layer is next.

Positional + Relational

Menlo is a Positional Play team in structure — but our identity pulls us toward relational behavior around the ball, the goal, and the moment of penetration.

LOGIC	THE QUESTION IT ASKS
Positional	Organizes through space and structure. "Where should I be?"
Relational	Organizes through interaction and proximity. "What's happening around the ball, and how do I plug in?"

BY THIRD

Defensive third

POSITIONAL

Structure first. The +1 through the #6, GK, or outside back creates a numerical advantage to build.

Middle third

HYBRID

Positional reference points remain, but relational behaviors activate when we draw an opponent in. Up-Back-Through and the Diagonal Ball live here.

Final third

RELATIONAL

Structure dissolves into interaction. Third-man runs, dummies, give-and-gos, overloads. This is the Spine at full expression.

STAY AND PLAY

A uniquely Menlo relational idea. When we have a numerical advantage on one side of the field, we do not switch — we stay and solve the overload where the ball is.

IN THE FINAL THIRD

We stop coaching positions and start coaching relationships. Patterns are not the priority. Recognition is.

Transitions

The threshold between Invade and Hunt, and back again. Two moments, each with a named vocabulary.

Defensive Transition

WE JUST LOST THE BALL

First action: read. If we have numbers, **Repress** — immediate pressure on the carrier. If we don't, **Sink and Squeeze**. The tactical foul (**Ending**) is available in the opponent's middle third, their final third, or our middle third when a runner threatens behind.

Offensive Transition

WE JUST WON THE BALL

First action: **First Look Forward** — Seek at its most urgent. The runners **Stretch**. The carrier scans vertical first. The Knife lives here.

Proactive Defending

WHILE WE ATTACK

The shape we attack in is the shape we will defend from. Players off the ball are the rest defense — the boundary Spring respects.

THE FIRST THREE SECONDS

The first three seconds after losing the ball define the next thirty.

III

PART THREE

The Structures

Five pressing structures, four named attacking moments.

The Family of Pressing Structures

Hex is the primary — the engine of Menlo defending. Hex+ and Horns are active variations. Solo is the 4-2-3-1 default, currently uncommon. Lock is a man-to-man high press used rarely.

STRUCTURE	WHEN WE USE IT
Hex	Primary.
Hex+	Variation — jump press on the CB swing.
Horns	Variation — funnel to central congestion.
Solo	4-2-3-1 default.
Lock	Man-to-man, rare.

THE COACH CALLS THE SWITCH

Structure changes come from the touchline, not the players. This aligns with Self-Discipline and protects young players from having to read game state at speed.

Hex

4-4-2 · DENY CENTRAL · TRIGGER-BASED

Overview. Structured 4-4-2 defensive pressing shape designed to deny central progression, control space between the lines, and force opponents into wide areas where we initiate pressure triggers — Step, Seal, Snap — especially when the ball is played to an outside back.

PLAYER	RESPONSIBILITY
#9 / #10 (Step)	First presser; angles run to force play wide.
#9 / #10 (Seal)	Screens the pivot; steps aggressively if the ball comes central.
Wide Mids (Snap)	Start narrow to protect the ½ space; press the OB wide when the trap is triggered.
Pivots	Protect central lanes; compact with the back line.
Back line	Maintain vertical control and communication for recovery.

EXECUTION

Opponent reaches the confrontation line and plays to the outside back → wide mid steps wide while the forward seals the inside lane → pivots slide to deny vertical channels → if the press fails, the team immediately sinks to regain compactness.

Hex+

JUMP PRESS ON CB SWING

Overview. When the opponent swings the ball from one CB to the other, the weak-side wide mid releases to press the receiving CB and force play back inside.

PLAYER	RESPONSIBILITY
Weak-side wide mid	Releases to press the CB once the ball is swung.
Opposite wide mid	Tucks in to maintain midfield compactness.
#9	Seals the central option and angles the pressing run.
#10	Screens the pivots; sinks or joins the trap if timing is right.
Pivots	Slide to cover the ½ space; strong-side OB is ready to step to the opposing winger.

THE TIMING CUE

Step on the pass, not the touch.

Horns

FUNNELS TO CENTRAL CONGESTION

Overview. Coordinated high press designed to force play into central trap zones. The front line curves its pressure inward like horns, while the midfield lines stay compact and ready to trap or step. Best used high up the field off an opposition goal kick or GK restart.

ROLES

First presser initiates pressure wide; second presser mirrors the opposite side. The #8 steps to the top of a diamond; #7/#11 come inside; the #6 sits at the bottom. 2-for-1 defending is necessary. Back-line players must be ready to step into midfield.

EXECUTION

First presser curves to block the sideline and cut off the OB → second presser reads the trigger → midfield lines slide together to compress central space. Timing: compact the lines before pressing; don't press too early.

CONTENT GAP — NOT YET PARALLEL

Horns does not yet carry a roles table, and Lock carries neither execution nor triggers. This is a known content gap being fixed separately — the five structures are not designed as visually parallel here on purpose.

Solo

LONE FORWARD INITIATOR · CURRENTLY UNCOMMON

Overview. The default pressing shape when we play a 4-2-3-1. A key point: don't leave the #9 isolated — he moves in coordination with the #7/#10/#11 in a diamond shape, trapping to one side once the opponent is committed.

PLAYER	RESPONSIBILITY
#9	Initiates the press alone, angling pressure to one side.
#7 / #10 / #11	Jump press triggers off the #9's angle; cut lanes or press CBs / OBs.
Double pivot (#6 + #8)	Step to support when the line is broken; cut vertical access.
Back line	Holds height with alertness to depth threats; outside backs prepared to step.

TRIGGERS

CB receives a square ball under light pressure · poor first touch or back-foot reception · pass into an OB with body shape closed to the field · GK roll-out or short goal kick to a CB.

Lock

MAXIMUM DISRUPTION

Overview. Functionally a man-to-man high press. Used rarely — deployed when the moment calls for maximum disruption: late in games to suffocate, or against an opponent struggling under pressure. Committing a foul high up the pitch is acceptable in the right moment.

MARKING PRINCIPLES

Front two cover the CBs and GK · the #6 waits central and picks up the strong-side 8 or 10 · our #8 picks up their #6 · the weak-side CM is shared through the weak-side CB and the weak-side #7/#11. Early chase and pressure.

ROLE CATEGORIES

1st Press Line: forwards pick up the back line. 2nd Press Line: midfield units pick up opposition midfielders. Trappers / Shadows: cut passing lanes. Backline / Anchors: hold marks tight. Control / Safety: defend the counter if the trap fails.

Attacking Moments

Four named moments — the Wave expressed as repeatable pictures. New moments are named only after they are confirmed in games.

1/2 Space

When. An attacker (typically the #10 or an #8) drops between the opposition's lines, in the half-space between their CB and OB, where the opponent can't track player and ball at once. **Resolution.** Turns and attacks if face-up · sets to a third-man runner if back-to-goal.

Up-Back-Through

Three-touch vertical combination. Play vertical to a high target (the up); support arrives underneath as the back option; the third runner attacks the space behind (the through). *Move on the intention, not the action* — the run starts before the bounce is played.

Diagonal Ball

Field-stretching switch from deep. The opponent shifts ball-side; a deep player (CB or #6) plays a diagonal to the weak-side wide mid or outside back, who receives with space and time.

Cutback

Wide entry + pull-back to the arriving wave

When. A wide player drives into the byline area in the final third, then pulls the ball back to attackers arriving at the edge of the box or the penalty spot. High-quality chance creation from a low-volume shot zone.

Trigger. Defenders collapse toward their own goal, facing their own net · the pull-back lane opens behind the retreating line · the Arrival layers are populated.

Resolution. First-time finish from the arriving wave · if the lane closes, keep the territory and Reload.

PROVENANCE

Identified in the 2025 goals data as a high-quality chance-creation pattern; named and locked into the library August 2026.

IV

PART FOUR

The Roles

Position by position — vision profile, behavior in each moment, top non-negotiables.

Reading the Roles

In possession, role positioning is context-dependent.

The shape adapts to opponent press, game state, and personnel. We don't over-specify what is genuinely read-based.

Out of possession, role positioning is locked.

Positioning is locked to the named press structure called by the coach — Hex, Hex+, Horns, Solo, and Lock each have specific assignments per position.

THE WAVE IS POSITION-AGNOSTIC

Any player can be the seeker, the runner, the releaser, or the arriver. The tables that follow describe defaults and non-negotiables, not caps.

1 Goalkeeper

Strong shot-stopping, organization, communication, and decision-making. Ability to build out and distribute in the right moments. Consistency is key. Know your ability and be sure the team knows your abilities. We want to know how we could concede and avoid anything outside those moments. Always communicating!

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	The 5th defender. Build-first sweeper-keeper when called for. Long-ball outlet when conditions warrant (weather, opponent over-committing, changing rhythm).
Out of Possession	Hybrid — high when we press (Hex+, Horns, Lock), deeper when in a mid-block or defending a lead. Vocal organizer — the voice that holds shape when chaos hits, from minute 0 to 90.
Def. Transition	Communicate first, position second — direct the back four through the recovery. Focus on weak-side defenders tucking in — often it's the weak side that saves the day.
Off. Transition	Push higher to support possession — outlet for the recycle. Move with the team — step up as we step up, maintain compactness.
Set Pieces	Holds the line on crosses, claims only what's clearly his. Zonal positioning at near post or center of goal vs. inswingers. Organizes the wall on free kicks — final call on positioning.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Consistency — same level every game. Communication never stops · distribution matches the moment · part of the shape (high when pressing, deep when sinking) · great body language is leadership in action.

4 · 5 Center Backs

Good in the air, sturdy and strong. Can defend 1v1 and provide cover. Brave — last-minute interventions and shot blocks. In possession, link-up players finding first-line passes and simple solutions. Channel and over-the-top distribution. Strong communicators.

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	Wide split when the GK has the ball is the default — stretches the opponent press, opens the central lane. Tighter / asymmetric / step-up variations deploy based on opponent press. Build-out behavior is read-based.
Out of Possession	Read the moment — step when the receiver is back-to-goal, stay deep when they're facing forward with runners. One steps, one covers — ball-side aggressive, far-side drops as cover.
Def. Transition	Sink and Squeeze — the back line collectively sinks for depth and squeezes toward center to deny penetration.
Off. Transition	Read game state — step when we have numbers, hold when we don't.
Set Pieces	Attacking corners: designated targets in the box. Defending corners: zonal positioning (near post or central).

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Brave · strong communicator · wins the air · 1v1 dominance against the opposing striker.

2 • 3 Outside Backs

Mobile and athletic. Good 1v1 defenders, good in the air and on overhead balls. Ability to get forward and make thrusting runs into the final third. Attacking characteristics are important and necessary, but defending is the primary function.

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	Fully dependent — all possibilities (stay deep, push to the OB-OM line, asymmetric, invert into the half-space, triggered thrusting run). The moment dictates. Defending is the primary function and is the locked, predictable behavior.
Out of Possession	1v1 stopper — wins the duel against the opposing winger, arm-across-hip. Sink and Squeeze — narrows to the CB to deny central penetration.
Def. Transition	Sprint back into shape — priority is getting behind the ball into the back four. Sink and Squeeze — narrow with the back line, deny central first.
Off. Transition	Provides the width and the outlet — the first pass out of pressure often goes to the OB. Weak-side OB is the natural swap partner for the far #8 on the Ninja run; if he takes it, the #8 fills the vacated hold slot. The call is a swap, not an addition.
Set Pieces	Set piece roles are individual assignments, not positional. See Section V.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Defending is the primary function. 1v1 dominance • mobility • aerial wins.

6 Holding Midfielder

Good in the air and breaking up plays on the ground. Simple linking up — connects the lines. Does not need to be a playmaker, but receives the ball under pressure and doesn't turn it over. With more time, can hit diagonal balls. Stronger voice and good organizer of the players in front of him.

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	Build: three options, read-based on opponent press. Drop in — between the CBs, forming a back three and pushing both outside backs higher. Drop out — alongside one CB, forming an asymmetric three. Or hold as a single pivot. If the opponent marks the #6 man-to-man, the ball-side #8 can take the drop instead — same move, different player.
Out of Possession	Screens the back four. Compact with the back line — part of the squeeze in Hex. Stronger voice — organizes the players in front of him. Wins aerial duels.
Def. Transition	First to the loose ball — hyper-mobile, anticipates, wins the second ball. Tactical foul (Ending) — willing to commit the foul to kill the counter. Reads vertical threats — covers in behind if a CB steps out.
Off. Transition	Holds position as the link — ready to Reload the ball if the first option doesn't go.
Set Pieces	Individual assignment, not positional. See Section V.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Receive under pressure and don't turn it over · stronger voice · ready to jump lines, aggressive in midfield defending, strong in the air.

8 Center Midfielder

Fitness and range to get box-to-box. Secure in possession; ability and vision to play longer-distance passes into the front line and the final third. Can also combine in tight space and take players on in the right places.

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	Fully dependent. Build and invasion moments both read-based. The #8 reads the opponent press, the personnel around him, and the moment. The box-to-box engine role means the #8 adapts to fill whatever the game requires — link, drop, runner, combiner, switcher. Must be able to protect the ball in Zone 19.
Out of Possession	Must know the defensive scheme and his responsibilities. Box-to-box defensively — recovers and presses both ways. Needs to both step lines and win balls, but also sit next to the #6 and screen passes in the right moments.
Def. Transition	A good proactive defender. Strong positioning allows for good repress moments along with tactical fouls (Ending). Willing to run all the way back to our defensive box to stop an attack.
Off. Transition	Ready to go forward immediately on the dribble or with a pass. Willing to run all the way to the attacking box to score — the from-deep layer of the Arrival.
Set Pieces	Individual assignment, not positional. See Section V.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Engine — fitness and range · secure in possession, doesn't turn the ball over under pressure.

7 • 11

Wide Mids

Pace and power, OR like another 8. In either case: ability to cross and be a goal threat. Defends well in wide areas. Willingness and desire to make runs into the box and shut the back door.

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	One of two skill sets — great 1v1 isolated, or good in combination and able to work the ½ space well during the build. In either case, once we are in the final third they are good crossers and finishers. Runs into the box — shuts the back door on far-side crosses. Cutbacks from the wide channel.
Out of Possession	Snap onto the opposing OB — the Hex trigger when the ball goes wide. Start narrow — protects central / half-space first, snaps wide on the trigger. Stays narrower on the weak side. Releases on Hex+ to press the receiving CB.
Def. Transition	Sprint back to the wide-midfielder slot — priority is restoring the 4-4-2 Hex shape. Repress the carrier if the ball is lost in the wide channel and numbers favor.
Off. Transition	Recognizes when to stretch the field and break out, and when to support the ball. Ready to release and run for the team more often than not.
Set Pieces	Individual assignment, not positional. See Section V.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Pace and power OR like-another-8 • crosses and goal threat • wide 1v1 defending • box-to-box stamina.

10 Second Striker / ACM

Depending on personnel and game situation, this player's role can vary. Willingness to make runs behind the back line and work off the 9, but can also come into midfield. A goal threat. Desire to dribble at players in the attacking third — draw fouls, put opponents on the back foot, beat them 1v1.

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	Drops between lines into pockets — links to the strikers. Makes runs behind — partners the #9. Dribbles at defenders 1v1 to draw fouls. Combines with the #8s. Final pass and cutback creator from the half-space.
Out of Possession	Steps aggressively on central passes. Screens the opposing pivot — denies the #6 receiving free. Partners the #9 in the 4-4-2 Hex front line.
Def. Transition	Reads numbers first — represses hard when they favor us, since he is usually the closest man to the loss in central areas. Ending is available in their middle or final third. If numbers don't favor, he drops into the front two and sets the Hex line.
Off. Transition	First Look Forward — leads the counter, runs in behind. Dribbles at the back line under pressure. Stretches behind — the run that pins the back four backward.
Set Pieces	Individual assignment, not positional. See Section V.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Goal threat · makes runs behind · 1v1 ability · comes into midfield when needed · sets / bounces — the friendly face in Up-Back-Through.

9 Striker

Good size and strength. Holds the ball up with pressure on his back; makes runs behind the back line. Stretches the back line and is patient for the ball to come to him — does not drop into midfield to search for the ball. Strong desire to score and be selfish.

MOMENT	WHAT HE DOES
In Possession	Stretches the back line — stays high. Holds up with pressure on his back. Runs behind. Patient — waits for the ball, doesn't drop. Combines with the #10. Channel runs — attacks the gap between CB and OB. Selfish in a shooting position.
Out of Possession	Initiates the Hex press — first presser, angles run to force play wide (Step). Initiates the Solo press. Seals the central option. Curved press on Horns. Marks the opposing CB on Lock. Doesn't drop — stays as the high point of the press shape.
Def. Transition	Usually the furthest man from our goal — his repress is about delay, not the tackle: angle the carrier away from the vertical line and buy the shape three seconds. If the ball has already passed him, he recovers to the high point of the press shape rather than chasing.
Off. Transition	Ready to release immediately to stretch the game. If his team needs help, he can come to the ball and hold it up.
Set Pieces	Individual assignment, not positional. See Section V.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Strong desire to score · confidence · stretches the back line · first presser · hold-up ability.



PART FIVE

The Set Pieces

The five named roles, the +1 rule, the named libraries.

Why Set Pieces Matter

25–35%

OF D-II GOALS COME FROM SET PIECES

18.8%

OF OUR 2025 GOALS — SIX OF THIRTY-TWO

This is the highest-ROI training time in the program. Set pieces are also where the +1 rule lives — we never want to be scored on off our own set piece, including throw-ins.

REST DEFENSE

The +1 Rule

If they send 2 high on a corner, we keep 3 back. Always one more than their attacking outlay. This rule is tied to Self-Discipline — we don't gamble on the back end. Composition adapts based on game state. Throw-ins are included.

THE RULE

Always one more than their attacking outlay.

The Five Named Roles

Individual assignments per player, not tied to a positional default. A CB might be the Target on one routine and the Cover on another.

ROLE	RESPONSIBILITY
Decision Maker	The player who calls or cancels the routine on the pitch. Reads the moment. Has authority to make decisions and change things up.
Cover	Proactive defending behind the set piece. Protects against the counter.
Ninja	The top-of-the-box player on attacking corners. Attacks rebounds or recycled crosses. Doubles as a proactive defensive option — the same arrival instinct codified in the Arrival's from-deep layer (Section II).
Screener	Sets the pick that frees the target. Legal screening and blocking movement.
Target	The designated header or shot target inside the box.

STILL TO BE CAPTURED

Per-routine assignments — the full list of routines × player slots is a separate Playbook page.

Attacking Corners & Free Kicks

Attacking Corners

Base · 6 Pack · Stack · 20 Tri Snake · Newcastle · 32 · Arsenal · Westmont. Each routine has a specific shape with assigned roles. Inswinger or outswinger varies by routine.

Attacking Free Kicks & Kickoffs

Free kicks: Ajax · Barca · Triangle. Kickoffs: Weber · PSG. FK takers by zone — designated by foot: direct shot range within 25y, indirect into the box at 25–35y, far-side cross deliveries at 35y+.

Defending Set Pieces

Refer to the Digital Playbook defending pages. The GK is the final voice on wall positioning.

BLOCKED SHOTS

Goal-line clearances are urgent, last-ditch efforts to prevent a goal when the keeper is beaten. Defenders must stay alert, react quickly, and sacrifice their body to clear the ball off the line.

VI

PART SIX

Match Management

Dialling the model to the moment — what changes with the scoreline, and where the model lives outside this document.

Game Management

GAME STATE	RESPONSE
Winning by 1 (min. 70+)	We drop the line of confrontation, tighten the vertical band, and shift the press structure toward containment. We don't change who we are — we adjust the dials.
Losing late	We push the LoC higher, accept Hex+ or Lock, and show willingness to commit fouls high (Ending) to prevent counters. The bias shifts from territorial protection to chance creation.
Level late	Default state. Play our way. Can depend on what result we need in a given game.

THE STANDARD

We don't change who we are. We adjust the dials.

Visual Artifacts

LOCKER ROOM	The Wave, the eight values, the identity statement, the Eight Attacking Principles.
PRACTICE WHITEBOARD	Daily session plan and principle of the day. Large whiteboard with capacity to print and paste physical artifacts.
CONES · BIBS · MARKERS	Show structures in real time.
DIGITAL PLAYBOOK	Video and diagrams of named patterns, accessible to players.
MATCH-DAY CARDS	Per-player roles, non-negotiables, opponent-specific notes.
GAME-DAY MEETING	Lineup, opponent overview, key principles for the game.

A living document — content evolves; vocabulary holds.

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